

Use Sourcetrail to Work Easily with Unfamiliar Code

This article introduces the reader to Sourcetrail, a cross-platform source explorer, formerly known as Coati. Though Sourcetrail supports C, C++, Java and Python, we'll focus on C/C++ in this article.



Have you ever tried to explore any source code without proper documentation? You will know the complexity of code analysis that is unfamiliar. Many cross-reference tools are available in the market, some of which are proprietary and some are limited to the command line. Sourcetrail is one such tool, which is free and open source, with a rich visual interface.

Source code analysis and visualisation support from this tool makes life easier for programmers, debuggers and testers alike, making them more productive with unfamiliar source code. Unlike debugging or profiling tools, this is a static analysis tool, i.e., it indexes the entire code

without execution. Thus, there is no narrowing down of indexing.

Setup

You can download Sourcetrail from <https://www.Sourcetrail.com/downloads> and follow the steps given in <https://www.Sourcetrail.com/documentation/#Installation> for installation. Here is a brief summary of the setup in the Linux environment:

- Download *Sourcetrail_xxx_Linux_64bit.tar.gz*
- Extract and run *install.sh* with admin privileges.
- This will install to */opt/Sourcetrail*, and *symlink* is created under */usr/bin/Sourcetrail*.
- You can now launch it using the

command *Sourcetrail* or create a desktop launcher shortcut.

Getting started

Once you launch Sourcetrail, a wizard appears to create a new project; you can open the existing project or choose from recent projects.

Let's go through some steps on how to create a new project and visualise some C++ source code as an example.

- Click on *Project -> New Project* and fill in the project name and location.
- Click on *Add Source Group*, and choose the *Empty C++ Source Group* under C++.
- Choose the desired C++ standard in the next wizard, and skip cross-compilation options for now.

